

apps such as F-Secure which can work as a spy-guard. If you're still uncertain there is always the option to backup your data and restore the phone to its factory settings or run an OS upgrade.

For phone calls whether using the telecom network or the internet, the options are far more limited. The prevalence of burner phones in India isn't that common but it is still possible to obtain disposable prepaid SIMs for private calls in some parts of the country. It's best not to hold on to the numbers and not give them out – only use them to make the necessary phone calls. However it is worth noting that voice analysis is already in the works so the only solution to remain untracked is to turn to voice distorting tools that make it harder (and perhaps impossible) for an automated system to detect and locate you.

A few mobile apps have also come to the rescue such as the open sourced project RedPhone Beta which aims to be an alternative on Android devices for making calls. The app routes all the calls via its own VoIP network which is fully encrypted but can only work between RedPhone Beta phones. The app is currently in development and is still working out its glitches but remains a solid option for those who need privacy. The sister application from RedPhone is called TextSecure that performs the same role but for messages. An added benefit of TextSecure is that it encrypts the messages on your device as well. In the case of the device being attacked for information the messages remain protected.

Real World Vulnerabilities

Digital spying can only go so far. Tracking your online habits, email and social media messages, along with the occasion over hearing of your phone conversations can often times not yield the kind of information some perpetrators are looking for – that can only be gained through real world intrusions. So if you feel like you may be under direct surveillance then your options are even more limited. To begin with, the most likely device you're likely to find are listening devices or GPS trackers. In many cases both of these are a singular item placed inside your phone physically. They can appear to be like a small memory card and are placed adjacent to the battery of your mobile device. If

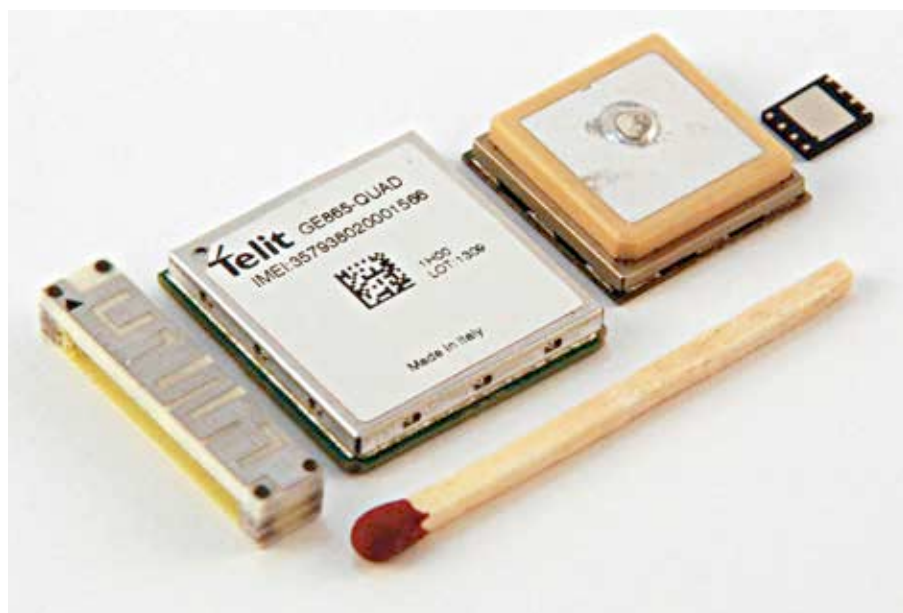
you find one there you know you're being tracked for real.

A good tool to keep on hand to detect such spying devices is a bug sweeper. Since bugs used to track people operate on a wireless frequency you can purchase a professional wireless radio frequency bug detector which can alert you to any listening devices in your environment. Although you should know that in the case of serious professionals they don't even require a physical bug. Using sound-wave patterns that resonate in objects people can listen and record conversations

and ears of others. But remember, if you've been singled out for pursuit there is very little you can do to escape.

Paranoid Existence

The irony is that the technology we embraced decades ago, with the promise that it will connect us, has in turn left us exposed, naked and vulnerable. It is no longer possible to envision a world where we no longer use the internet or have mobile devices accompanying us everywhere. After all the benefits imparted to us through them enrich our



Surveillance devices come in many shapes and forms and can be impossible to detect unless you're really looking.

using just ordinary cameras. And similarly the lightwave patterns on an LED screen can be used to mirror an active screen. Any form of direct line-of-sight visual between you and a tracking agent can leave you at risk of being bugged. But these latter technologies are extremely high end and only found being used by government agents.

The simplest recourse in the real world to avoid surveillance is to keep a watchful eye out for unusual changes in your environment. The occasional bug sweeping can help but with certain intermittent signal pulse sensors it's very likely that some bugs wouldn't be active at the time of the sweep. The habit of keeping your sensitive and private activities in a secret, undisclosed and completely controlled environment is the best way to ensure hundred percent privacy from the eyes

lives by making access to education, entertainment and each other more easier than ever. But on the other side of this technology are vicious criminals and insidious governments intent on using this technology against people. It is a war between us and the invisible purveyors of our privacy in some distant corner of the world. So is this a war worth fighting? Are we truly helpless in the defence of ourselves?

Perhaps not against in our very own nation. Here in India all we need to do in order to fight back isn't to just download a bunch of apps and buy a bunch of gadgets, but to reach out to our elected officials and hold them accountable for their actions. Demand the change we need and curb the over-arching reach of these systems. That is in spirit the way of democracy and it begins with you. 